

Global Markets Daily: Heated Rivalry—USD/CAD and The USMCA Review

- USMCA negotiations have mostly flown under the radar, but the July 1 deadline is drawing closer, and we think increasing trade policy uncertainty could be a more meaningful headwind to CAD in the months ahead.
- While USMCA would remain in effect if negotiations extend past the deadline, we think markets will continue to grapple with a USMCA exit as a credible risk given the process the last time around. We expect ongoing talks will likely proceed bilaterally with US-Canada talks proving more difficult, mirroring the original USMCA process and the 2025 fentanyl-related tariffs.
- We construct an index of “trade conflict” headlines, measured as a share of total trade-related news articles, which suggests that negotiations with Canada were more contentious than those with Mexico. We find that increasing trade tensions affect CAD in both spot markets—via US-Canada rate differentials—and in low-delta options, with less impact on realized or implied ATM volatility.
- We see three key market implications. First, USMCA negotiations are likely to be more strained with Canada and therefore a more important driver for CAD than MXN. Second, elevated trade uncertainty should weigh on CAD performance by potentially deterring investment and keeping the Bank of Canada on the more dovish end of the central bank spectrum. Third, while trade policy uncertainty has historically had less impact on implied ATM or realized volatility, we see value in low-delta USD/CAD options as the deadline approaches.

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Heated Rivalry—USD/CAD and The USMCA Review

USMCA negotiations have mostly flown under the radar, but the July 1 deadline is drawing closer. Several headlines have suggested that President Trump is considering exiting USMCA in favor of separate bilateral agreements. While the ultimate outcome remains uncertain, negotiations are increasingly likely to extend past the July 1 deadline. In that scenario, USMCA would remain in effect¹, but we think markets would continue to grapple with a USMCA exit as a credible risk given the process the last time around. We expect ongoing talks will likely proceed bilaterally—with US-Canada talks proving more difficult—and we think this could be a more

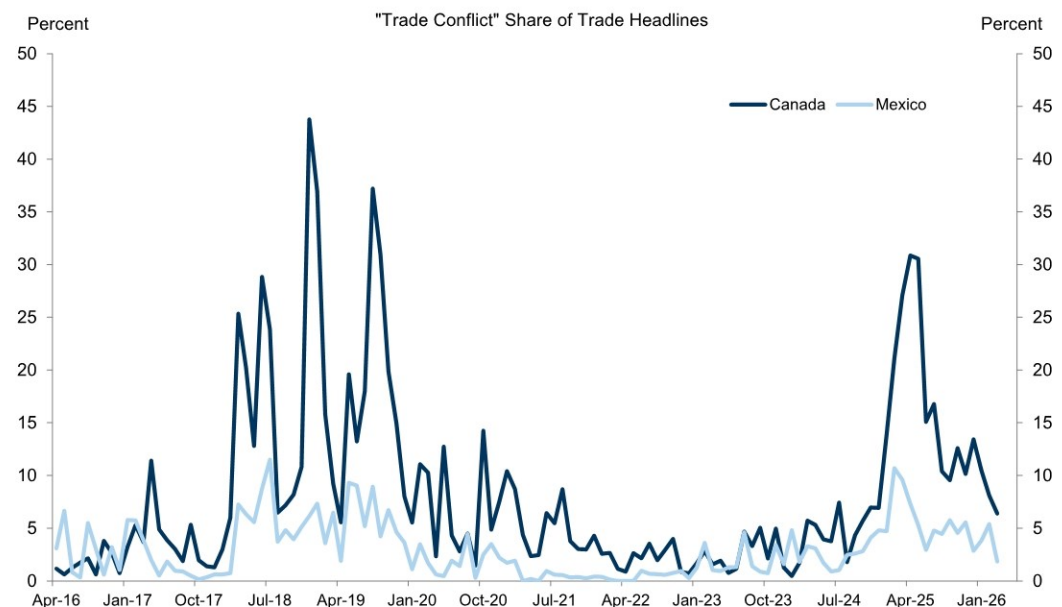
¹ If a party does not agree to extend USMCA by the deadline, the agreement would remain in effect but requires the parties to conduct additional annual joint reviews until all parties agree to extend the agreement for another 16-year period or until USMCA terminates. The joint review process is separate from USMCA's withdrawal provisions, which allow any party to withdraw from the agreement with six months' written notice to the other parties. <https://www.congress.gov/crs-product/R48787>

meaningful headwind to CAD in the months ahead.

So far, negotiations have largely unfolded on a bilateral basis; the US and Mexico began the first official bilateral negotiating round excluding Canada this week in Mexico City. While Trade Representative Greer has pointed to progress in US-Mexico discussions, US-Canada trade talks have reportedly fallen behind, echoing the original USMCA trade deal process.

We construct an index of “trade conflict” headlines as a share of trade-related news articles. Coverage suggests that negotiations with Canada were more contentious than with Mexico (Exhibit 1), consistent with subsequent insider accounts. In 2018, an ultimate agreement between the US and Canada was delayed by various sticking points while discussions with Mexico were relatively (and surprisingly at the time) cooperative. As it was later revealed, two separate agreements were very much a possibility, and Canada only ultimately agreed to the deal last minute.

Exhibit 1: News coverage suggests that negotiations with Canada were more contentious than with Mexico

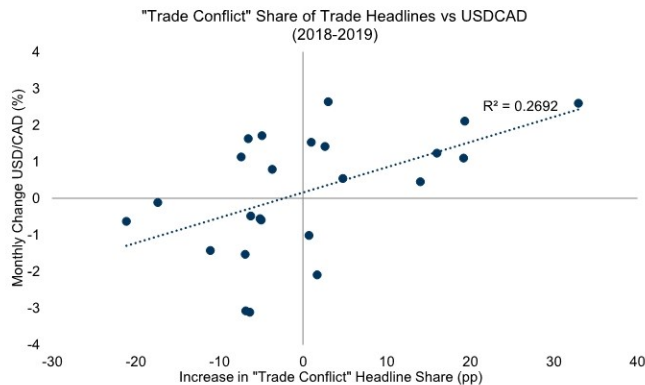


We use Bloomberg News Trends to produce a count of news stories containing “trade war”, Canada (or Mexico), and USA, and separately “trade”, Canada (or Mexico), and USA. We then take the “trade war” share of total trade headlines for each country.

Source: Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

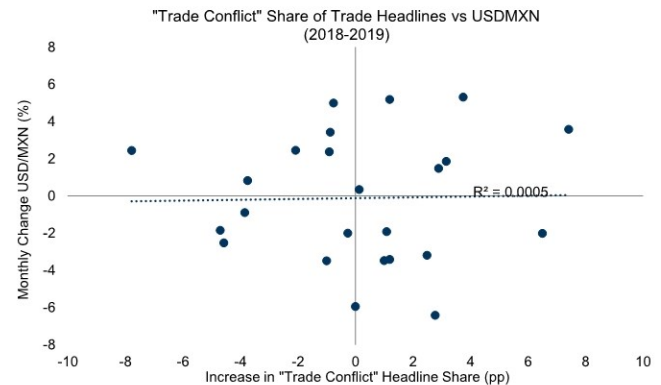
We have found that the US trade relationship is a key driver of longer run trend moves in USD/MXN and specific announcements and escalations do impact the currency. That said, we expect ongoing USMCA uncertainty to have a more muted impact on MXN than on CAD, given that tensions have so far been more elevated with Canada than with Mexico, as they were in 2018–19. Over this longer time horizon, increasing trade conflict was associated with CAD weakness (Exhibit 2) but had a more limited impact on MXN (Exhibit 3). We expect this round of USMCA negotiations could similarly be more strained with Canada—and therefore a more meaningful negative impulse for CAD this time around.

Exhibit 2: Over 2018–2019, increasing trade conflict was associated with CAD weakness...



Source: Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

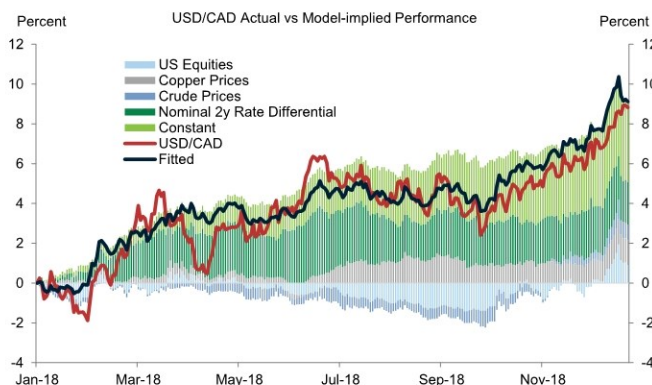
Exhibit 3: ...but had a more limited impact on MXN



Source: Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Although USD/CAD tends to rise when trade tensions escalate, we find markets price limited trade-specific premium beyond standard cyclical drivers in our GSBEER models. During the NAFTA renegotiation, pockets of trade premium emerged around key events, but USD/CAD otherwise remained broadly in line with fundamentals ([Exhibit 4](#)). Similarly, during the 2025 fentanyl-related tariffs and Liberation Day uncertainty, the moves in USD/CAD were largely explained by rate differentials ([Exhibit 5](#)).

Exhibit 4: We find markets price limited trade-specific premium beyond standard cyclical drivers in our GSBEER models



Source: Goldman Sachs FICC and Equities, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

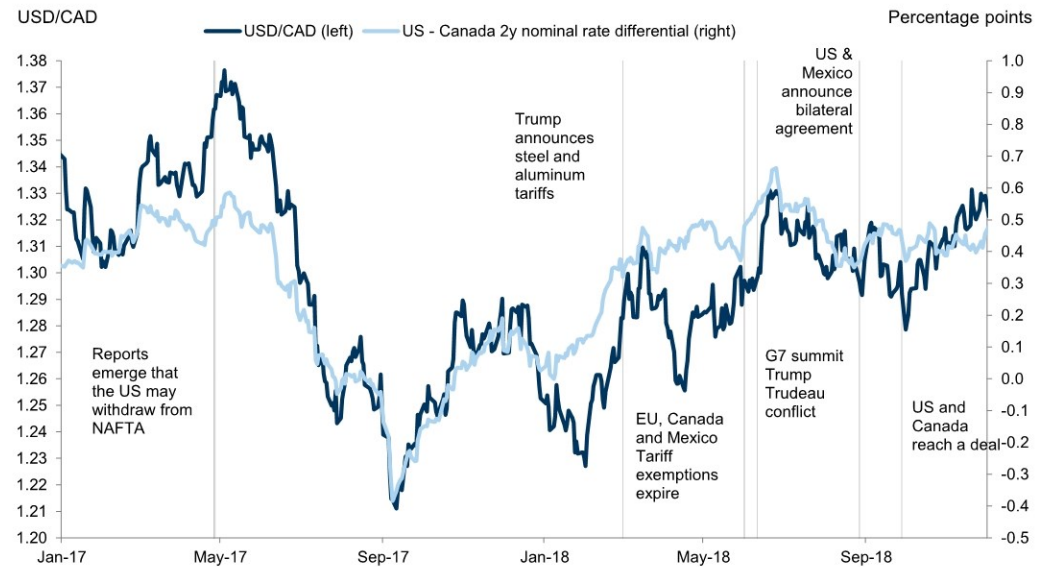
Exhibit 5: During the 2025 fentanyl-related tariffs and Liberation Day uncertainty, the moves in USD/CAD were largely explained by rate differentials



Source: Goldman Sachs FICC and Equities, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

We attribute this limited premium to the BoC's incorporation of trade policy uncertainty—and consequent adverse impacts on activity—into its reaction function, both in 2018 and more recently. For example, in April 2018 the BoC noted that “interest rates may need to remain below the neutral range until... uncertainty around trade conflicts...has dissipated.” More recently, the April statement highlighted that new trade restrictions could warrant further easing to support economic growth. Despite hikes priced, our economists note that the hurdle remains high for the BoC to adjust the policy rate in the face of heightened trade policy uncertainty, underpinning their expectation for the BoC to remain on hold through 2026. In this way, trade shocks more durably impact the USD/CAD via rate differentials, rather than as a sustained premium over traditional cyclical drivers. Accordingly, trade headlines have tended to move USD–CAD rate differentials and USD/CAD together ([Exhibit 6](#)).

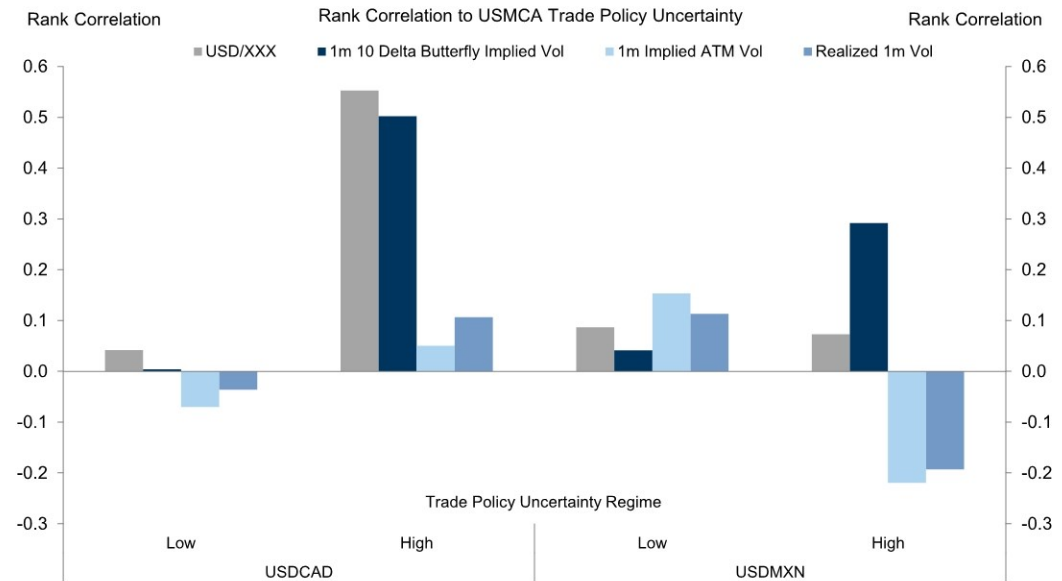
Exhibit 6: Trade headlines have tended to move USD-CAD rate differentials and USD/CAD together



Source: Goldman Sachs FICC and Equities, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Rising trade tensions are also reflected in low-delta options, consistent with stronger demand for protection against policy-driven tail risks ([Exhibit 7](#)). We find that when trade risks are elevated, tail volatility in both CAD and MXN tends to track increases in trade policy uncertainty, though more closely in CAD. In contrast, the impact on realized and implied ATM volatility is generally more limited. 2025 was an exception, with realized and implied ATM volatility more highly correlated with increases in trade policy uncertainty around the fentanyl-related tariffs and Liberation Day. However, barring a more disruptive exit from USMCA, we expect ongoing USMCA-related uncertainty would generate a more similar market response to 2018-2019.

Exhibit 7: Rising trade tensions are also reflected in low-delta options, consistent with stronger demand for protection against policy-driven tail risks



Regimes calculated as the top and bottom third of a 60-day rolling average of the USMCA uncertainty index (BBUNTPXM Index). Sample 2016-Present.

Source: Bloomberg, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Trade uncertainty into the July 1 USMCA deadline will be a key risk for CAD. We see three main market implications of increasing trade uncertainty in the months ahead. First, USMCA negotiations are likely to be more strained with Canada and therefore a more important driver for CAD than MXN. Second, elevated trade uncertainty will be a headwind to spot CAD performance by potentially deterring investment and keeping the Bank of Canada on the more dovish end of the central bank spectrum. Third, we see value in low-delta USD/CAD options as the deadline approaches because these have historically moved more reliably with rising trade tensions than implied ATM vol. Ultimately, while elevated energy prices have supported the currency since the onset of the energy shock, rising trade uncertainty is one reason on the margin we remain less constructive CAD relative to other pro-cyclical commodity exporters in the more medium term.



Best Trade Ideas Across Assets

For pricing, charts, and a list of previous recommendations, please visit our [Trade Ideas page](#).

1. Stay short SGD/MYR, opened January 24, 2026, at 3.13, with a target at 2.90 and a stop at 3.30, currently trading at 3.11.
2. Stay long TRY, NGN and KZT against the USD, as an equally weighted basket, opened February 18, 2026, at 0%, with a total return target of 7.5%, and a revised stop of

0%, currently trading at 1.7%.

3. Stay long USD/SEK, opened March 20, 2026, at 9.3443, with a target at 9.65 and a stop at 9.00, currently trading at 9.2528.
4. Stay long 3y France, Spain, Italy vs OIS (equally weighted), opened April 10, 2026, at 0.33, with a target at 0.23 and a revised stop at 0.32, currently trading at 0.30.
5. Stay long MSCI Korea and Taiwan (equal weight) vs. short MSCI India, Philippines, Thailand (equal weight), opened April 16, 2026, at 100, with a revised target of 135 and a revised stop of 115, currently trading at 133.
6. Stay short EUR/HUF, opened 17 April 2026, at 361, with a target of 350 and a stop of 372, currently trading at 355.
7. Stay long 3y SOFR swap spread, opened 17 April 2026, at -22.6bp, with a target at -18bp inclusive of carry; and a revised stop at -23bp, currently trading at -20.3bp.
8. 2s5s CAD steepener, opened 24 April 2026, at 20bp, with a target at 35bp and a revised stop at 20bp, current trading at 22bp.
9. Stay short USD/EGP, opened 24 April 2026, at 0%, with a total return target at 6% and a stop at -3%, currently trading at 1.9%.
10. Stay long 5y5y EUR OIS – HICP, opened 01 May 2026, at 1.09%, with a target at 0.88% and a stop at 1.22%, currently trading at 0.99%.
11. Stay long 5y Receivers on 3m 2s5s10s Receiver Fly (bp running), opened 09 May 2026, at 1bp, with a target at 10bp and a stop at -5bp, currently trading at -1bp.

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